

Collaborative Learning Discussion: Summary Post

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Reflecting on my initial post, peer feedback and the three units has deepened my understanding that security and risk management is not simply about identifying technological threats; it requires a structured assessment of how threats, vulnerabilities, users and organisational decisions interact. This distinction is important in human-rights investigations, where technological capability can simultaneously reduce and create risk.

Hancock et al. (2024a; 2024b) demonstrate that AI, satellite imagery and OSINT can strengthen evidence gathering, yet incomplete or biased data may create vulnerabilities that produce misleading conclusions. The risk-management process therefore requires risks to be identified, assessed and treated rather than assuming that technologically generated evidence is inherently reliable. Threat modelling provides a valuable analytical mechanism because it encourages investigators to examine how threats could exploit vulnerabilities and what controls are proportionate to the resulting risk.

The peer responses extended this analysis by highlighting that users and affected communities are themselves critical components of the risk environment. Human-rights impact assessments, meaningful participation, data provenance and confidence ratings can expose uncertainty and identify potential harms throughout the technology lifecycle. Importantly, participation should influence requirements, deployment decisions and acceptable-risk thresholds rather than become tokenistic consultation.

The units also reinforce the need to combine technical, organisational and human controls. Data minimisation, encryption, restricted access and defined retention

periods can mitigate privacy risks, while corroborating digital evidence with independent sources and contextual testimony reduces over-reliance on algorithmic outputs (Koenig et al., 2021). Independent auditing can further identify systemic bias and strengthen accountability (Jobin, Ienca and Vayena, 2019).

Overall, my perspective has shifted from viewing technology primarily as an investigative solution towards recognising it as part of a dynamic risk system. Effective security management consequently depends on continuous assessment, threat modelling, stakeholder involvement and proportionate controls, ensuring innovation enhances, rather than undermines, fairness, accountability and human rights.

References

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